

language constraints, but 'hello tunes' was a hit. In fact, they are like a *pehchaan* or personality status for rural customers."

Due to infrastructural and other cultural barriers, companies are innovating to serve the rural consumers' needs better. Samsung has specially developed a solar-powered mobile phone, while consumer goods companies have attempted to offer refrigerators with 12-hour power back-

need to travel to charge the phone. Ravinder Zutshi, deputy MD of Samsung India, says, "Keeping this in mind, we developed Solar Guru, the world's first solar charging mobile phone."

While companies may have overcome their mindsets about rural consumers, communicating with them remains an uphill task, because of poor penetration of mass media and accessibility problems. Given that these con-

ble van. It's important to build a connect with the consumers, so we organise plays and puppet shows through which we convey the brand message."

Gold Plus, for instance, routinely takes rural consumers to its factory and showrooms in small towns to educate them on purity levels of gold jewellery. Everyday, 1,000 people are ferried to the factories from numerous villages. Under its savings scheme consumers can deposit Rs 250 every month with Gold Plus and buy a piece of jewellery at the end of 15 months.

The most important factor, however, is the relevance of word-of-mouth publicity in the hinterland, which is why compa-



Airtel DTH Services

RURAL INITIATIVE: The company offers top-ups and selection of movies in local languages. It has divided the market into three sizes—urban centres (C&S homes), urban-rural (TV but no cable homes) and no-TV-no-cable homes. Airtel accounts for 23 per cent of all the new DTH connections every month.

RURAL SALES: 3 lakh* DTH connections

ALL INDIA SALES: 10 lakh* DTH connections

*Approximately

NOKIA LIFETOOLS PROVIDES INFORMATION TO RURAL CUSTOMERS ON WEATHER, MANDI PRICES AND CROPS.

RURAL SALES: 16 mn phones per annum*

*Estimates

up. Samsung, for instance, has launched stabiliser-free Direct Cool refrigerators that can withstand voltage fluctuation and semi-automatic washing machines. While rural consumers require similar products as their urban counterparts, their needs are slightly different due to infrastructure conditions. A market survey found that rural consumers need a durable mobile phone with a long-lasting battery because of erratic power supply and long distances consumers

sumers are not as savvy as urban consumers, corporates are adopting innovative techniques to reach out and communicate with them. Companies mostly deploy mobile vans with their communication decoratively painted on them and accompanied by an ambassador, who entertains and conveys the brand's key message to the local populace. Most often this person is a local whose word they trust. Explains Sinha, "It's not enough to be present in a village by setting up a stall or mo-

nies like Hero Honda spend more time connecting with opinion makers like village headmen and headmasters of local schools. So from putting up banners at weddings, wishing the couple a happy married life to convincing panchayat members on the benefits of certain products, the trick is to capture the imagination of the key opinion makers. Customer acquisition in rural areas may be difficult, but retaining them is not because the rural consumer is not as fickle. ■